



Narrative Style and the structure of Kurdish and Neo-Aramaic folktales

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Outline of the talk

- Story openings
- Story endings
- The verb ‘to rise, to get up’ to organise the narrative into episodes
- Idioms and Phraseology

3. NARRATIVE STYLE AND DISCOURSE IN KURDISH AND NEO-ARAMAIC ORAL LITERATURE¹

Paul M. Noorlander and Masoud Mohammadirad

Northern Iraq is the homeland of a wide range of linguistic minorities with closely intertwined traditions transmitted orally over numerous generations of bi- and multilinguals. The Neo-Aramaic speaking communities—both Jews and Christians—used to be an integral part of this once vibrant, multilingual oral culture, now disappearing rapidly. The resulting commonalities of their coexistence with the Kurdish speaking communities can be found in almost every aspect of linguistic structure (e.g. Noorlander 2014; Haig and Khan 2018), including their oral literature and its stylistic features.² Thus, the shared folkloristic traditions of the Kurds, Jews and Christians of Northern Iraq are also reflected in the parallel style of storytelling and use of idioms. This chapter provides a succinct overview of some of the stylistic and linguistic devices found across the Kurdish and Neo-Aramaic oral

¹ We are grateful to Dorota Molin and Geoffrey Khan for their helpful comments on an earlier draft of this chapter.

² E.g. Garbell (1965), Chyet (1994), Coghill (2009, 2020a), Khan (2009). See also Molin, Chapter 2 in this volume.



Paul Noorlander



Story openings

Story openings

There Once Was / There Was One

(1) Central Kurdish

got=ī zamānē xò=y| qašàk ha-bu̠|

گۆتی زهمانی خۆی قهشهک ههبوو

It was said that there once was a Christian priest.

(CK. Shaqlawa, Text 38: The Foul-Mouthed Priest, §1)

(2) Neo-Aramaic

ʿamriwa ʿəθwa xàʿa, xa malka ʿəθwale t̰laθà bnone.

They said **there was one**, a king who had three sons.

(ChA. Harmashe, Text 33: Mirza Muhammad and the Three Princesses, §1)

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

(3) Central Kurdish

ha-bū na-bū Mām Dzardāk ha-bū.

هه‌بوو نه‌بوو مام جەردەک هه‌بوو

It is said that once upon a time (lit. there was and there was not) there was [a man called] Uncle Jarda. (CK. Shaqlawa, Text 22: A Talking Goat, §2)

(4) Neo-Aramaic

ʾəṭwa=w ləṭwa xa mām-telona ʾəṭwa.

There was and there was not, there was an Uncle Fox.
(ChA. Shaqlawa, Text 12: A ‘Pious’ Fox, §1)

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

- **W. Armenian**

<i>gar</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ch-</i>	<i>gar</i>
(there)was	and	not	(there)was

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

- **W. Armenian**

<i>gar</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ch-</i>	<i>gar</i>
(there)was	and	not	(there)was

- **Persian**

<i>yeki</i>	<i>bud</i>	<i>yeki</i>	<i>na-bud</i>
One	(there)was	one	not-(there)was

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

- **W. Armenian**

<i>gar</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ch-</i>	<i>gar</i>
(there)was	and	not	(there)was

- **Persian**

<i>yeki</i>	<i>bud</i>	<i>yeki</i>	<i>na-bud</i>
one	(there)was	one	not-(there)was

- **Turkish**

<i>bir</i>	<i>varmış</i>	<i>bir</i>	<i>yoxmuş</i>
one	there.was	one	not.there.was

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

- **W. Armenian**

<i>gar</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ch-</i>	<i>gar</i>
(there)was	and	not	(there)was

- **Persian**

<i>yeki</i>	<i>bud</i>	<i>yeki</i>	<i>na-bud</i>
one	(there)was	one	not-(there)was

- **Turkish**

<i>bir</i>	<i>varmış</i>	<i>bir</i>	<i>yoxmuş</i>
one	there.was	one	not.there.was

- **Romanian**

<i>era</i>	<i>și</i>	<i>nu</i>	<i>era</i>
(there)was and	not	(there)was	

Story openings

There Was / There Was Not

- **W. Armenian**

<i>gar</i>	<i>u</i>	<i>ch-</i>	<i>gar</i>
(there)was	and	not	(there)was

- ***Arabic**

<i>kān</i>	<i>mā</i>	<i>kān</i>
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- **Persian**

<i>yeki</i>	<i>bud</i>	<i>yeki</i>	<i>na-bud</i>
one	(there)was	one	not-(there)was

- **Turkish**

<i>bir</i>	<i>varmış</i>	<i>bir</i>	<i>yoxmuş</i>
one	there.was	one	not.there.was

- **Romanian**

<i>era</i>	<i>și</i>	<i>nu</i>	<i>era</i>
(there)was and	not		(there)was

Story openings

There was None Greater than God

(5) Central Kurdish

aḷē ha-bo na-bò | kas la xwāy gawratər nà-bo. | ئەڵێ هه‌بوو نه‌بوو كه‌س له‌ خواي گه‌ور‌تر نه‌بوو

It is said that there was and once there was not, but there was no one greater than God.
(CK. Shaqlawa, Text 29: Two Mullahs, §3)

(6) Northern Kurdish

هه‌بوو نه‌بوو كه‌س ژ خۆدێ مه‌زتر نه‌بوو كه‌س ژ به‌نييا دره‌وينتر نه‌بوو

ha-bū na-bū kas šə xudē maztər na-bū | kas šə banīyā dərawīntər na-bū. |

Once there was, once there was not, there was no one greater than God, no bigger liar than man.
(NK. Duhok, Text 26: Dindik Hinar – A Girl Called Pomegranate Grain, §2)

Story openings

There was None Greater than God

(7) Neo-Aramaic

ʿəṭwa=w ləṭwa | mən bāb ʿAlaha=w ʿoda Maryam bəš raba ləṭwa=w qāt=iš la k-awe. |

There was, there was not, there was no one greater than Father God and
Mother Mary and there never shall be. (ChA. Shaqlawa, Text 28: Two Mullahs, §2)



Story endings

Story endings

I came back from there and they gave me nothing

(8) Northern Kurdish

ئەم گەهشتینه دوماهیكا چیرۆكا خو، ئەز هاتمه‌قه چ نه‌دا من

am gahəştîn=a dumāhikā čīrokā xo | az hātm-ava čə na-dā mən.

We have arrived at the end of our tale. I have come back, but they (i.e. the protagonists in the tale) gave me nothing. (NK. Duhok, Text 17: A Woman and a Leopard, §37)

(9) Central Kurdish

amn=īš gaṛām-awa=ū hīts=əm pē na-bəṛā.

ئەمنیش گەر/امه‌وه هه‌چم پێ نه‌بێرا

As for me, I have come back [from these events] and they [i.e. the characters of the story] have given me nothing. (CK. Shaqlawa, Text 22: A Talking Goat, §10)

Story endings

I came back from there and they gave me nothing

(10) Neo-Aramaic

ana=š 'itèli, tsə məndi la wəlu qati.

I have come back, but they have given me nothing. (ChA. Shaqlawa, Text 12: A 'Pious' Fox, §38)

(11) Hawrami

wa mən=īč āmānē, hīč=šā na-dānē.

وه منيچ ئامانى هيچشا نه داني

And I too have come, they gave me nothing. (Gorani Luhon; MacKenzie 1966, 78)

Story endings

I came back from there and they gave me nothing

‘I came back from there and they gave me nothing’

Also occurs in Europe:

closing rhymes in Italian folktales collected by Italo Calvino in the 50s (Beckwith 1987);

closing formulas recorded in a collection of Serbo-Croatian folktales (Bošković-Stulli 1966, 312)

Story endings

Blessing of the Parents

(12) Northern Kurdish

o řahmât əl day bābēt gohdārā|

ئۆر محمەت ل دەی بابیت گۆھدارا

May blessing be on the audience's parents.

(NK. Duhok, Text 34: Mirza Muhammad's Adventures, §113)

(13) Neo-Aramaic

kut šmele raḥmaṯa gawəṯ yəmmeh.|

Mercy on the mother of whomsoever listened.

(ChA. Duhok, Text 32: Mirza Muhammad and the Forty Monsters, §235)

Story endings

It is finished

(14) Central Kurdish

amn=îš hātm-aw | hîts=əm pē na-bəřā. | xalās=ū řoy. | ئەمنیش هاتمهوه هیچم پێی نهبر، خه لاس و ڕوی

I came back, nothing was given to me. It is finished (lit. It is finished and gone.)
(CK. Shaqlawa, Text 19: A Ewe and a Wolf, §22)

(15) Neo-Aramaic

babay məθle; xləšla. |

Their father died; the story is over.
(ChA. Harmashe, Text 33: Mirza Muhammad and the Three Princesses, §47)



The verb 'to rise, get up' in clause linkage

The verb ‘to rise, get up’ in clause linkage

(16) Northern Kurdish

راتبن ئەوی ژنی ئازاد تکهن و تگهل خو تبهن شکەفتی

řā-t-ban awē žanē āzād aṭ-kan | ū aṭ-gal xo aṭ-ban=a aškafṭē.

Then (lit. they rose) they freed the woman and took her with them to the cave.
(NK. Duhok, Text 30: The Girl, Her Evil Stepmother and the Old Witch, §83)

(17) Neo-Aramaic

qamle ʿay masəqθa kulla šitale b-reše dānne ḥambušaye.

Then (lit. he rose) he threw the entire torch over the heads of these monsters.
(ChA. Duhok, Text 32: Mirza Muhammad and the Forty Monsters, §80)

The verb 'to rise, get up' in clause linkage

- found across space and time in Semitic, e.g. Aramaic, Arabic (Fischer and Jastrow 1980, 76; Lahdo 2009, 170), Hebrew (Dobbs-Allsopp 1995; Chrzanowski 2011, 356ff.)
- found its way into Northern Kurdish in NW Iraq, not attested in Central Kurdish (?)



Idioms and Phraseology

Idioms and Phraseology

There is Fire in Your House

(18) Central Kurdish

ئهو ئاگره‌ی له ماری تۆ بوو له ماری منیشت به‌ردا

aw āgəray la mārē tū bû | da mārē mən=īš=ət bar-dā!

Your life was hell and you inflicted the same hell upon me (lit. The fire that existed in your house, you threw it at my house too.) (CK. Shaqlawa, Text 29: Two Mullahs, §12)

(19) Neo-Aramaic

’āt betux nura ’itən gu betux ’arqətwā mənē ’āna šəne,

Your home was like hell (lit. There is fire in your house) from which you fled all these years.
(ChA. Shaqlawa, Text 28: Two Mullahs, §17)

Idioms and Phraseology

A Day Came A Day Went

(20) Northern Kurdish

řož hātən=o řūž čòn|

ڕۆژ هاتن و ڕۆژ چوون

Several days passed by (lit. days came and days went).

(NK. Duhok, Text 26: Dindik Hinar – A Girl Called Pomegranate Grain, §16)

(21) Neo-Aramaic

zàlle yoma| θèle yoma|

‘As the days passed by (lit. a day went a day came).

(ChA. Dohok, Mirza and the forty monsters, §6)

Idioms and Phraseology

Coming Going

(22) Northern Kurdish

هات و چۆ هات و چۆ نهزانی دی چ کهتن بهر هف خاریقه چوو

hāt=o čò | hāt=o čò. | nà-zānī dē čə katən. | bar-av xārē va čū.

She went back and forth. She did not know what to do. She went downstairs. (NK. Duhok, Text 26: Dindik Hinar – A Girl Called Pomegranate Grain, §74)

(23) Neo-Aramaic

zəle=w θèle | zəle=w θèle=w | šitəle ganeu l-aw bara xəna.

He went back and forth, back and forth, and flung himself to the other side. (ChA. Harmesha, Mirza and the three Princess, §24)

Idioms and Phraseology

It Is Not in My Hands

(24) Northern Kurdish

ma çê dastê ma dā nî=na!'

مه چ دهستی مه دا نینه

We—we cannot manage it! (lit. there is nothing in our hands.) (NK. Duhok, Text 34: Mirza Muhammad's Adventures, §109)

(25) Neo-Aramaic

b-idati lèwa?

I cannot help it? (lit. It is not in my hands.) (ChA. Shaqlawa, Text 12: A 'Pious' fox, §34)

Idioms and Phraseology

Examples from European languages (Piiranien 2012)

Night and day

To be/ fight like cat and dog

To be someone's right hand

To play with fire

To take someone under one's wings

زۆر سپاس

Hawitun bäsime

Thank you